of his brother; now, with rebels in retreat, Hakim chastised, and critical maulanas exiled, ‘everything reached perfection’[8] – and no one would dare tell the emperor what he might or might not do. ‘I’ll drink no coffee, bring me wine!’ goes one of Akbar’s most carefree lines of verse. ‘I’ll play no harp – bring me my flute!’[9]

At thirty-nine, the emperor could, at last, rule with a free hand.

~

A measure of the untrammelled extent of Akbar’s authority was taken the very next month, when the unfortunate Makhdum-ul-Mulk and Abdun Nabi tried to cut short their reluctant pilgrimage to Mecca.

In April 1582, Akbar rode out of Fatehpur to greet a caravan of his female relatives. Chief among them was his aunt Gulbadan, yet to write her wonderful memoir, along with Salima, Bairam Khan’s widow and then Akbar’s wife, and even Askari’s widow Sultan Begum, who had taken such tender care of her hostage nephew in Qandahar. It was seven years since Akbar had met them: the ladies had left Fatehpur in 1575, were stranded in Gujarat awhile, and sailed for Mecca in 1578.[10] They were back in Hindustan after three and a half years and many adventures, including a shipwreck in Aden. Akbar and his realm had changed a great deal since the ladies had last met him. When they left Fatehpur, for example, Abdun Nabi was a powerful sadr; on their return, the poor man, along with Makhdum-ul-Mulk, sought to smuggle himself back to the capital under their protection.

It was news of the Bengal rebellion that had tempted the two scholars to come home; news of its failure reached them too late. When they landed in Gujarat, hoping to hear that the nightmare of Akbar’s reign was over, they learnt of his victory instead. Akbar, too, learnt of their unauthorized return and sent men to arrest them (‘in such a manner that the ladies should not know of it’, writes Abul Fazl). Makhdum-ul-Mulk was so terrified, it seems, that he died en route, in Ahmedabad.[11] Abdun Nabi, possibly braced by angry resentment against a man who had once treated him with such deference, summoned the courage to appear in court, and even spoke a few rude words to the emperor, at which, according to Badauni, Akbar hit him in the face.